



A Place To Call Home

_Housing Difficulties for Afghan Newcomers in
Ontario, Canada_

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Introduction



Canada attracts the attention of many different prospective immigrants. Despite Canada attains more and more fascination for these immigrants possible to have better life. On the other side, newly arrived Afghan Canadians in Ontario , Canada experience different housing hardness during resettlement. This project aims to dig out the housing problems Afghan newcomers face during resettlement in Ontario,Canada and what possible actions can be taken to mitigate these difficulties.

Upon arriving in Ontario province, many Afghan newcomers encounter significant housing difficulties, often resulting in prolonged stays in hotels and reception houses. These challenges can be daunting and exacerbate the stress of resettlement. It is imperative to identify and address these barriers to ensure a smoother transition and improved quality of life for Afghan newcomers in Ontario province's cities like Toronto, Ottawa...

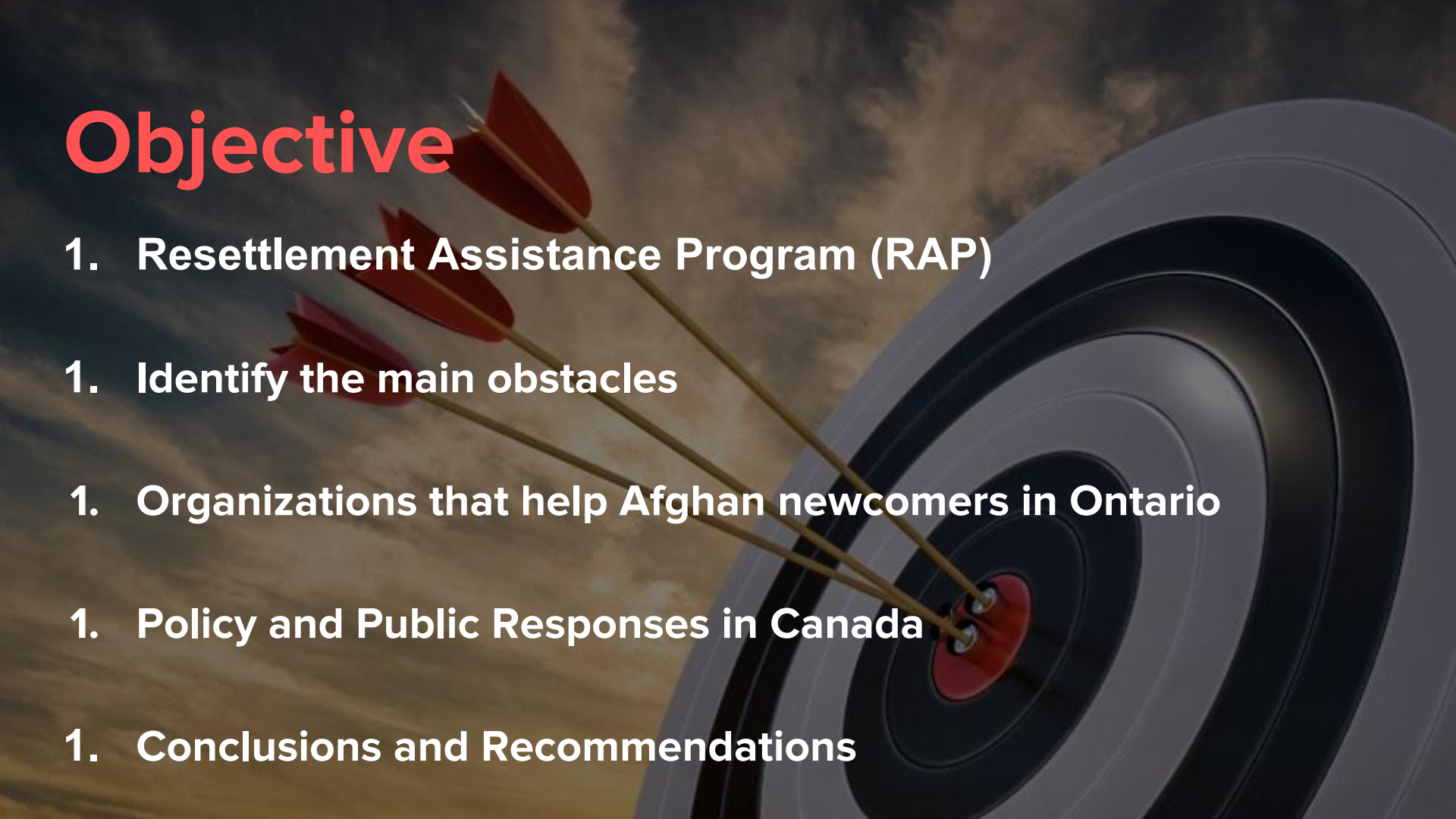


“Sometimes called ‘Little Syria’ or ‘Little Afghanistan,’ two east-end highrises have long been a landing place for newcomers to Ottawa and country. But a mix of low-income tenants from all parts of the world call the Donald Street towers home.”



<https://www.cbc.ca/newsinteractives/features/donald-street-ottawa-not-the-canada-they-dreamed-of>

Objective

A large, dark grey target with concentric rings is positioned on the right side of the frame. Four red arrows with gold shafts are embedded in the bullseye, which is a small red circle in the center. The background is a dramatic, cloudy sky in shades of grey and blue.

1. Resettlement Assistance Program (RAP)

1. Identify the main obstacles

1. Organizations that help Afghan newcomers in Ontario

1. Policy and Public Responses in Canada

1. Conclusions and Recommendations

1•Resettlement Assistance Program (RAP)

In July 2021, the federal government announced the establishment of a special program to resettle Afghans who were integral to Canada's efforts in Afghanistan. On August 13, 2021 the federal government announced an expansion of its regular resettlement program to include 20,000 additional Afghan refugees within the next two years. This program is for Afghans who have been forced to flee their country. As of October 4, the federal government has increased this commitment to resettle 40,000 within the same timeframe.

#Welcome
 Afghans



The Resettlement Assistance Program (RAP) is a contribution program through which the Government of Canada provides assistance for resettled refugees to establish themselves in their new home. The program has two main components: income support and a range of immediate essential services. The income support also has three components:

- Startup Allowances
- Monthly Income Support
- Transportation Allowance

2• Main Obstacles Faced by Afghan Newcomers in Accessing Housing in Ontario:

A• Affordability:

.Finding suitable and affordable housing for RAP newcomers has always been a challenging aspect of their resettlement program. RAP service providers face difficulties due to the very low monthly income provided by the RAP allowance, and these challenges have worsened in recent years as affordable rental housing in Ontario has become increasingly scarce. The amount included in the RAP allowance for housing costs is insufficient to cover rent for adequate housing without significantly reducing the household budget for other essential needs.

B.Lack of Housing for Large Families

The challenges of finding suitable rental housing for families with four or more children in the Canadian housing market have been acknowledged by Canada's federal housing agency for several years, as has the fact that the shortage of such housing disproportionately affects immigrant families, which tend to be larger than those of the Canadian born. 43 Prior to the Afghan Resettlement Program in Ontario, the larger family sizes and greater needs of recent refugee cohorts for intensive guidance and support (including accompaniment to appointments) when looking for housing had already increased the demands on housing-search and support workers.

- **Mismatch between where housing and services are available.**

Integration and settlement services for refugees and immigrants have tended to be delivered primarily in larger provinces of Canada including Ontario. These cities offer public transportation, specialized health care, and often, diaspora communities from refugees' origin countries who can provide additional support to newcomers. More affordable and larger housing units are often available in smaller cities, outer suburbs, and rural communities, but the limited availability of services in these locations has meant that refugees and settlement workers have often been unable to take advantage of otherwise suitable housing options.



C. Rapid Pace and Scale of Arrivals

In Canadian cities where the ramp-up of the Afghan Resettlement Program moved especially quickly, there was a sudden spike in housing demand. This contributed to significant bottlenecks in transitioning GARs (Government Assisted Program) from temporary to permanent housing, as RAP providers waited for government funds to hire more housing-search workers in order to expand their inventories of suitable rental housing units. Some providers also experienced delays in receiving the first checks (one-time payment for start-up costs as well as the first month's income support) so that leases could be signed, or in receiving furniture so that refugee newcomers could move into their new homes.

3•Organizations that help Afghan newcomers in Ontario

- 1-Catholic Center for Immigration(CCI)
- 2-AWO-Settlement Service To all Newcomers in Ontario
- 3-Afghan Association of Ontario
- 4-Thunder Bay multicultural Association
- 5-Ottawa REALTOR
- 6-The Ottawa Community Immigrant Services Organization (OCISO)

4•Policy and Public Responses in Canada

A. Extensive Pre-Arrival Planning and Stakeholder Coordination

Housing was a major component of city-level advance planning for the arrival of the first 20000 Afghan refugee newcomers. Planning networks included newcomer-serving organizations and municipal and provincial representative.

Several interview-based studies have underscored that the determination to meet the challenges of the Syrian operation generated an unprecedented degree of intergovernmental, intersectoral, and multi-scalar cooperation, beginning at the advance planning stage, and that this was crucial to the capacity of service organizations to find housing and react to contingencies once the newcomers began to arrive.

B. Voluntary and Private Support

The broader upsurge of volunteer offers and private-sector goodwill and support for the Afghan refugee resettlement effort was unprecedented.

In several cities, municipalities and nonprofit organizations, with the aid of donated technical expertise, set up online housing portals to help refugees and sponsor groups in their housing search. These platforms helped coordinate the numerous offers of housing from small landlords and private individuals not previously involved in housing refugee newcomers. In the early days of the operation, when the general public had limited information about refugee profiles and needs, many of the offers were unsuitable: units were either too small for large families, or only available for short-term rental.

With improved matching, the portals generated significant new sources of housing, and sometimes provided refugees with opportunities to live in neighborhoods that have not traditionally been places of newcomers settlement.

C. Fostering Connections at the Neighborhood Level

Over and beyond their RAP-funded settlement work, RAP providers and other newcomer-serving organizations also made use of programs funded by IRCC under the Settlement Program during the Afghan resettlement program . These include the Community Connections program and various provincially or municipally funded programs that aim to foster newcomer integration, including by helping refugees build familiarity with their neighborhood and the wider city and understand aspects of Canadian culture and lifestyle. Volunteer contributions are encouraged under such programs and were very forthcoming for the Afghan refugee operation.

D. Expanding Destinations

During the Afghan resettlement program, the federal government added seven new cities to the RAP program, most of them small cities, in order to ease housing pressures in the largest destinations, Toronto and Vancouver. This was done only after careful assessment of the local settlement infrastructure's capacity to provide services for refugees. Consideration was also given to employment opportunities for low-and semi-skilled workers, which in some cases included agricultural/food-processing operations. In these new smaller centers, finding suitable housing, notably for large families, was often, although not always, less of a challenge.

4. Conclusions and Recommendations

In a number of cities specially Ottawa the challenges of the Afghan resettlement program stretched the resources of RAP providers' housing placement staff—already strained by the combination of rising rents and changing GAR profiles"—to their limits.

Nevertheless, even in the most challenging housing markets, all Afghan newcomers were settled into permanent housing within a few months, and even sooner in many cases. volunteer support.

The outpouring of practical assistance and financial support from different segments of local civil society, volunteers, and housing providers, as well as greater networking and collaboration between newcomer-serving organizations like Catholic Center For Immigrants (CCI) and landlords and housing providers were all crucial ingredients in this success. These challenges were also catalysts for strengthening interorganizational and intersectoral information sharing and collaboration, as exemplified by municipalities co-organizing housing portals. And they have led to new thinking about how to most effectively mobilize.

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**THANK
YOU**

